Academic Research Paper Template

Title: (Concise and informative, accurately reflecting the content of the paper)

- The title should be specific, accurately summarizing the study.
- Avoid vague terms; be precise and use keywords that enhance discoverability.
- Consider framing the title to reflect the research question or main finding.

General Writing Guidelines:

- Follow the **PEER** structure: **Point, Evidence, Explanation, Repeat/Link**.
- Use **active voice** for clarity and engagement.
- Maintain logical flow and coherence between sections.
- Support claims with credible sources and properly cite them.
- Ensure conciseness and precision in language while avoiding unnecessary jargon.

Recommended Writing Order: Follow the **Inside-Out Writing Method**:

- Start with **Methods** (easiest to write as it describes what was done).
- Move to **Results** (simply report the findings).
- Write the **Discussion** (interpret findings in relation to existing research).
- Complete the **Introduction** and **Abstract** together (ensuring alignment with the full paper).

Abstract: (150–250 words summarizing the research problem, methods, key findings, and conclusion)

- **Background:** Why is this topic relevant now? What is the big debate or concern?
- **Gap in Knowledge:** What is missing from current research?
- **Study Contribution:** How does your study address this gap?
- **Population & Methods:** Outline study design, inclusion criteria, and data sources.
- **Results:** Key findings that are emphasized in the discussion.
- **Conclusion:** Main takeaway and implications for future research.

Keywords: (3-6 relevant terms for indexing and searching)

(Tip: We recommend writing a structured abstract and then 'suturing' it back together if you need an unstructured abstract. Be sure to check journal formatting for the specific abstract length and formatting style)

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1. Introduction

The introduction consists of three essential parts:

- **Why is this topic relevant now?** Frame the issue within a larger debate or concern.
    - Example: Ongoing debate about air pollution and COVID-19 transmission.
    - Example: Rising unemployment rates and their impact on mental health.

- **Existing state of knowledge and the gap in knowledge**
    - Example: Prior studies show mixed results, outdated findings, or weak methodologies.
    - Use others' critiques to highlight gaps or inconsistencies in the literature.

- **What did your study do to fill this gap?** Clearly define the study's value and contribution.
    - Example: Analyzing disciplines previously overlooked, incorporating the latest studies.
    - If applicable, justify why a systematic review was conducted instead of a meta-analysis.

(Tip: Keep sentences concise and use active voice. Be sure the GAP emerges clearly. Avoid overloading the introduction with unnecessary background information.)

2. Literature Review (optional - more relevant to social sciences)

- **Overview of Existing Research:** Summarize key studies related to your topic.
- **Gaps in Literature:** Identify contradictions, outdated studies, or methodological weaknesses.
- **Theoretical Framework (if applicable):** Introduce key theories or models guiding your study.

(Tip: Use PEER to structure each paragraph—start with a clear point, provide evidence, explain its relevance, and link to the next idea.)

3. Methodology

- **Study Design:** Describe whether the study is qualitative, quantitative, or mixed-methods.
- **Data Collection:** Specify databases, inclusion/exclusion criteria, and search strategy.
- **Sample & Eligibility:** Describe study population and selection process.
- **Data Analysis:** Outline the analytical approach (e.g., thematic analysis, statistical tests).
- **Ethical Considerations:** Mention any ethical approvals or considerations (e.g., informed consent).

(Tip: Use direct language to describe what was done and justify methodological choices. Keep it as linear as possible as if you were writing a cookbook for someone to recreate your recipe)

4. Results

- **Present key findings concisely.** Clearly state the most important findings.

- **Use visuals: Include tables, graphs, or figures** where relevant to summarise the results.
- **Highlight trends, patterns, or statistical outcomes.** Identify recurring themes or statistical outcomes
- Find a **structure** that enables your main points to emerge

(Tip: Avoid interpretation in this section; focus on presenting objective data. Use clear subheadings if necessary)

5. Discussion

The discussion follows this structure to explain what the results mean (whereas the prior section reported only what the data showed):

- **Recap of What You Found:** Summarize key findings.
    - Example: Our analysis finds evidence that unemployment was detrimental to mental health.
    - Key Finding 1 – This association was particularly strong in men.
    - Key Finding 2 – However, we did not find this effect among women.
- **Study Limitations (at least 3):** Discuss general methodological limitations.
    - Example: It was not possible to conduct a meta-analysis due to data inconsistencies.
    - Example: Sample sizes in included studies varied widely, limiting generalizability.
- **Limitations from Studies Themselves (applies to systematic reviews):** Identify specific issues in the reviewed studies.
    - Example: Many included studies had weak methodologies or lacked longitudinal data.
- **Strengths of Your Study:** Highlight the study's contributions.
    - Example: Comprehensive review of the latest studies in this domain.
- **Optional:** Coherence with existing research or grey literature.
- **Optional:** Incidental observations—unexpected but noteworthy findings.
    - Example: While focused on mental health, we observed that job loss was linked to divorce.
- **Implications for Future Research:** Identify gaps that future work should address.

    - Example: Future studies should explore how policy interventions can mitigate mental health impacts of unemployment.
- **Optional:** Implications for Practice or Policy.
    - Example: Policymakers should consider targeted support programs for unemployed individuals.

(Tip: Use active voice to emphasize key insights and their relevance. Avoid speculative claims that are not supported by your data. But do include these as possible avenues for future research or potential interpretations.)

6. References

- Use appropriate citation style (APA, MLA, Chicago, etc.).
- Ensure all sources cited in the text are listed here.
- Use Zotero or Endnote or another reference manager

7. Appendices (if applicable)

- Supplementary material, such as questionnaires, raw data, or detailed calculations.

Final Thoughts

- **Plan ahead:** Writing a strong paper takes time. Avoid last-minute efforts.
- **Stay focused:** Ensure each section contributes directly to answering your research question.
- **Seek feedback:** Engage with peers or mentors for constructive criticism.
- **Stay organized:** Use a reference manager to keep track of sources.
- **Think strategically:** Consider how your research fits into the broader academic conversation.
- **Follow the Inside-Out Writing Method:** Start with **Methods**, then **Results**, followed by **Discussion**, and finally **Introduction** and **Abstract** together.